

Adam Tankanow

Founding Engineer | tankthinks.net

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I'm the founding engineer at CloudZero. I joined pre-funding in July 2017 and helped build a multi-tenant SaaS FinOps platform from 0 lines of code and 1 engineer to ~270,000 lines of code, 40+ engineers, and 300+ customers. Along the way I made every category of mistake available — architectural, organizational, interpersonal, sartorial — and learned from most of them. I can now direct a swarm of AI agents through a codebase I've been building for nine years, which turns out to be a surprisingly useful skill when you've made all the mistakes the agents are about to make.

CloudZero: Founding Engineer (2017–Present)

Lines of code	0 → ~270,000
Engineers	1 → 40+
Customers	0 → 300+
Monorepo packages	158
Lambda services	100+
Cloud providers	3 (AWS, Azure, GCP)
Years	~9 and counting

The Platform. Serverless-first on AWS Lambda, API Gateway, EventBridge, SQS, SNS, DynamoDB, S3. Python and TypeScript. CloudFormation and Pulumi for IaC. GitHub Actions CI/CD.

Multi-Tenant Auth. Auth0, SAML, SSO, OIDC, API keys, RBAC, data access controls. Tenant isolation across every layer — compute, storage, API, event bus.

Data Pipelines. Billing ingestion from AWS, Azure, GCP — normalization into Snowflake. Custom dimension allocation DSL (CostFormation). Anomaly detection. Forecasting.

The Frontend. React + TypeScript. Evolved through Redux, Nx monorepo, TanStack Router/Query, Chakra UI. Multiple generations.

Multi-Cloud. Adapter pattern for AWS, Azure, GCP cost and resource data. Connector framework supporting 17+ providers.

AI Integration. Claude-powered cloud cost advisor (LangChain + LangGraph). MCP server. AI-driven ops tooling.

Everything Else. Internal CLIs, observability (SumoLogic, X-Ray), customer onboarding, billing data generator, Slack bots, Jira/ServiceNow integrations.

Non-Code. Sales engineering, customer support, product strategy, hiring, culture-building, incident response, documentation.

Certifications

- AWS Certified Solutions Architect — Professional (2019)

Publications

- *Effects of Oversampling on SNR Using Swept-Sine Analysis* — Audio Engineering Society, 2010
 - *Automatic Extraction of a Measure of Complexity from an Audio Sound File* — M.S. Thesis, University of Miami, 2007
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Before CloudZero

MassMutual — Application Engineer, 2015–2017. The “startup inside a Fortune 100” pitch. Learned a lot. Not the dream.

Nuance Communications — Sr. Software Engineer → Development Manager, 2008–2015. Operated speech recognition serving 3B transaction lines/year. Led monolith-to-microservices migration (DDD, Clean Architecture, Spring Boot). Won internal innovation challenge with patent-pending prototype. Led cross-functional incident response. Increased engineering conference attendance 100% two years running.

Dolby Laboratories — Implementation Engineer, 2007–2008. Helped Samsung, NEC, STMicroelectronics implement Dolby tech on embedded platforms.

University of Miami — M.S. Music Engineering Technology, 2007. Thesis: extracting complexity measures from raw audio. AES publication.

Bose Corporation — Software Engineer, 2004–2005.

Tulane University — B.S. Computer Science, 2004.

First Principles

- **Code is liability.** Write less of it.
 - **Understand the domain.** The best code clearly represents domain rules.
 - **Don’t break your consumers.** 99% of the time, it is uncalled for.
 - **Focus on flow.** Yours and your teammates’. Move value to the right.
 - **Respect the Lindy Effect.** Research ideas that have been useful for a long time.
 - **Write things down.** You won’t remember tomorrow.
 - **Strong beliefs, loosely held.** Have opinions. Change them when the evidence changes.
 - **Take long walks.** Find trees.
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The HTML version lives at tankthinks.net/experience.